Custom Information Aggregator - User Manual

Release Candidate Documentation Draft - 20 October 2026

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Custom Information Aggregator — User Manual

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CIA is a Windows desktop application that helps you inspect structured XML sources, choose the information you need, build a reviewable database, and export selected results to Excel workbooks.

This manual explains the **actual user interface**, using screenshots from a 30-file selection of Goodbooks XML files. You do not need to understand XML internals or software development to follow the main workflow.

> **Draft status:** This documentation is for review against the physically accepted CIA baseline (`6d16aabe74a5a8000dd46c60548e818ced92fde0`). It is not a claim that the final installer, website or public release is available. Screenshot callouts are documentation overlays, not controls inside CIA.

Find what you need

Goal	Read
Complete your first export	Quick Start
Understand every main workspace	Walkthrough
Learn about source and output sets	Sets and OutputSets
Save selection and blacklist profiles	Profiles and Blacklists
Control Database columns and Excel routing	Columns and Excel Configuration
Configure CIA and inspect activity	Settings and Diagnostics
Solve a problem	Troubleshooting
Check feature boundaries	Known Limitations

The workflow at a glance

Load → Discovery (Input → Output) → Create Database → Review → Export to Excel

1. **Load** XML files, folders or supported archives into a source set.
2. **Discovery / Input** inspects available tags and their structural contexts; you select the values you want.
3. **Discovery / Output** previews the proposed rows and OutputSets before building a Database.
4. **Database** materializes the approved output so you can review rows, columns and inclusion.
5. **Excel** routes included outputs into worksheets and workbooks, then saves the export.

The application groups related records according to their source structure by default. An optional **One row per source file** setting offers a different, wider projection for supported use cases.

Related documentation

- Installation Guide — installation, upgrades and uninstall instructions.
- Release Notes / What's New
- Support

Documentation conventions

Button labels and **setting names** match the visible CIA controls. Numbered circles in illustrations correspond to the numbered explanations directly below. Source paths have been anonymized in the manual's screenshots.

Quick Start — first workbook

This exercise uses **30 Goodbooks XML files** selected by the documentation author. The files are already available locally in the tutorial screenshots; the archive itself is **not included** with CIA or this draft. You can follow the same steps with your own supported XML files.

1 — Load the files

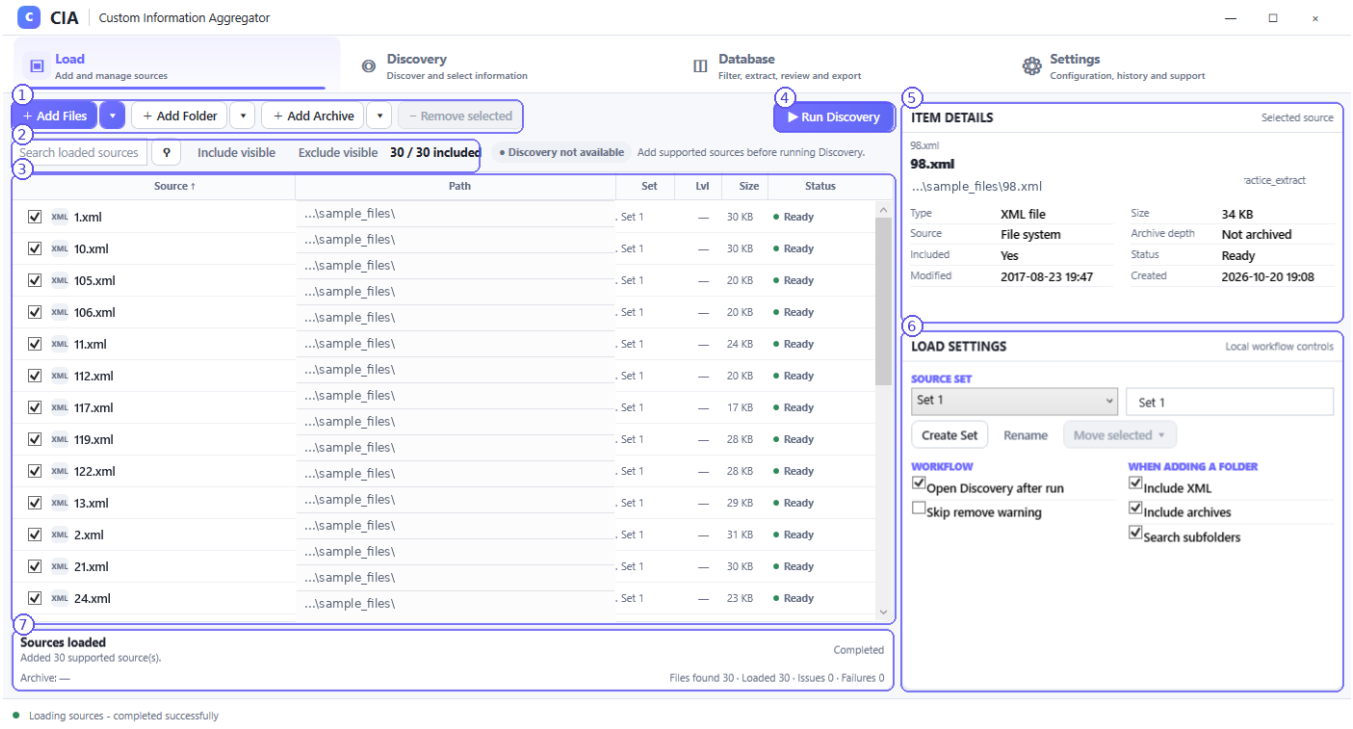


Figure 1: Annotated Load workspace showing the loaded sources and key controls

1. Open **Load** and select **Add Files** to choose XML files, or **Add Folder** to choose a folder containing them.

2. Confirm the list contains your intended sources and that each relevant source is **included** and **Ready**.
3. Leave the files in **Set 1** unless you need to organize separate inputs into additional sets.
4. Click **Run Discovery**. If **Open Discovery after run** is checked, CIA opens Discovery after a successful run.

2 — Select information

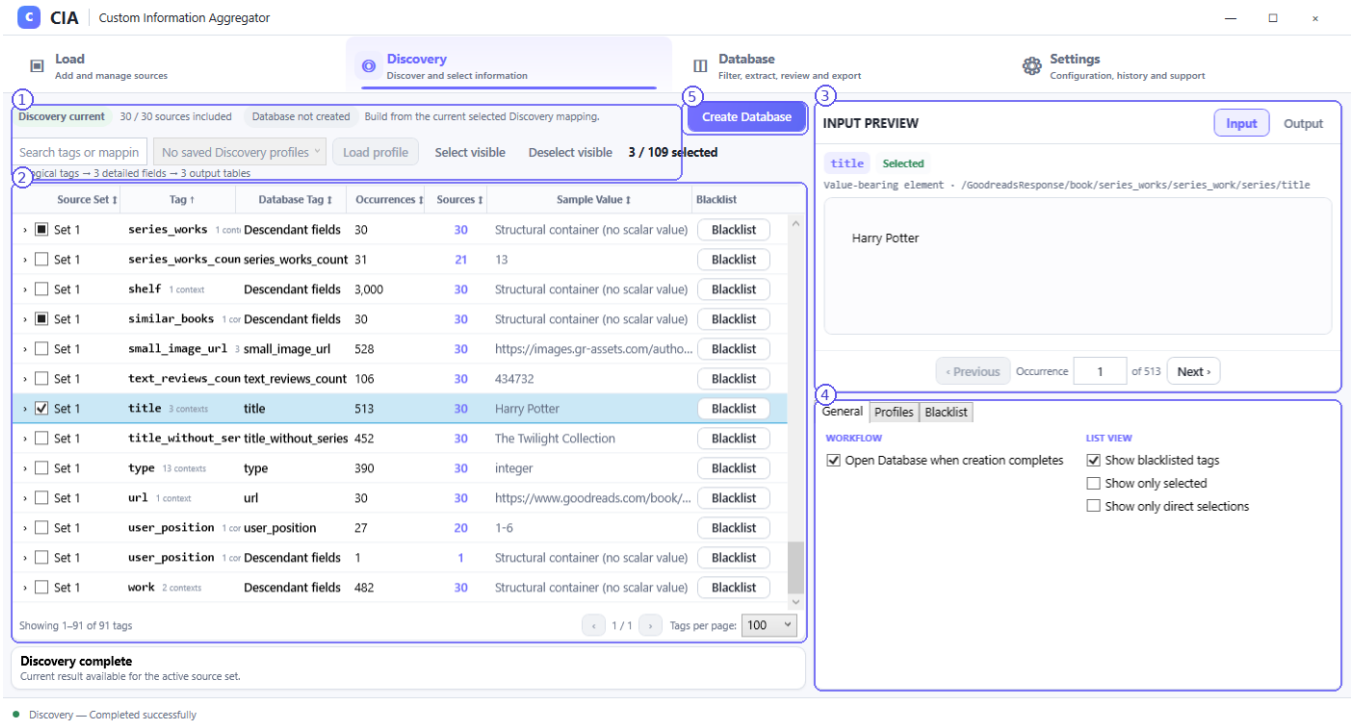


Figure 2: Discovery Input screenshot with source tag selection and preview

1. In **Discovery**, work initially in **Input** mode.
2. Search or browse the tags; expand a tag that has multiple structural contexts.
3. Use the checkboxes to select the specific values or contexts you want. In this example, the author worked with titles, authors and related information.
4. Check **Input Preview** to confirm that the selected occurrence is the value or field you intended.

3 — Inspect the proposed output

1. Switch from **Input** to **Output**.
2. Inspect **Output Preview** and the enabled **Output Sets**.
3. For a typical first run, leave **One row per source file** unchecked: **Preserve relationships** keeps structurally related records together.
4. Keep the desired proposed OutputSets enabled; disable any you do not need.
5. Click **Create Database**. The Database is generated from the current approved selection and output settings.

4 — Review and export

1. Open **Database** if CIA has not opened it automatically.
2. Review the rows and selected fields. Use **Columns** if you need to hide, rename or reorder fields.
3. Confirm that the required output is checked under **Excel Output Configuration**, with the intended workbook and worksheet names.
4. Select **Export to Excel** and complete the save flow. CIA may ask you to resolve a destination conflict if a workbook already exists.
5. Confirm the success result inside CIA. This manual does not require opening Excel to understand the application workflow.

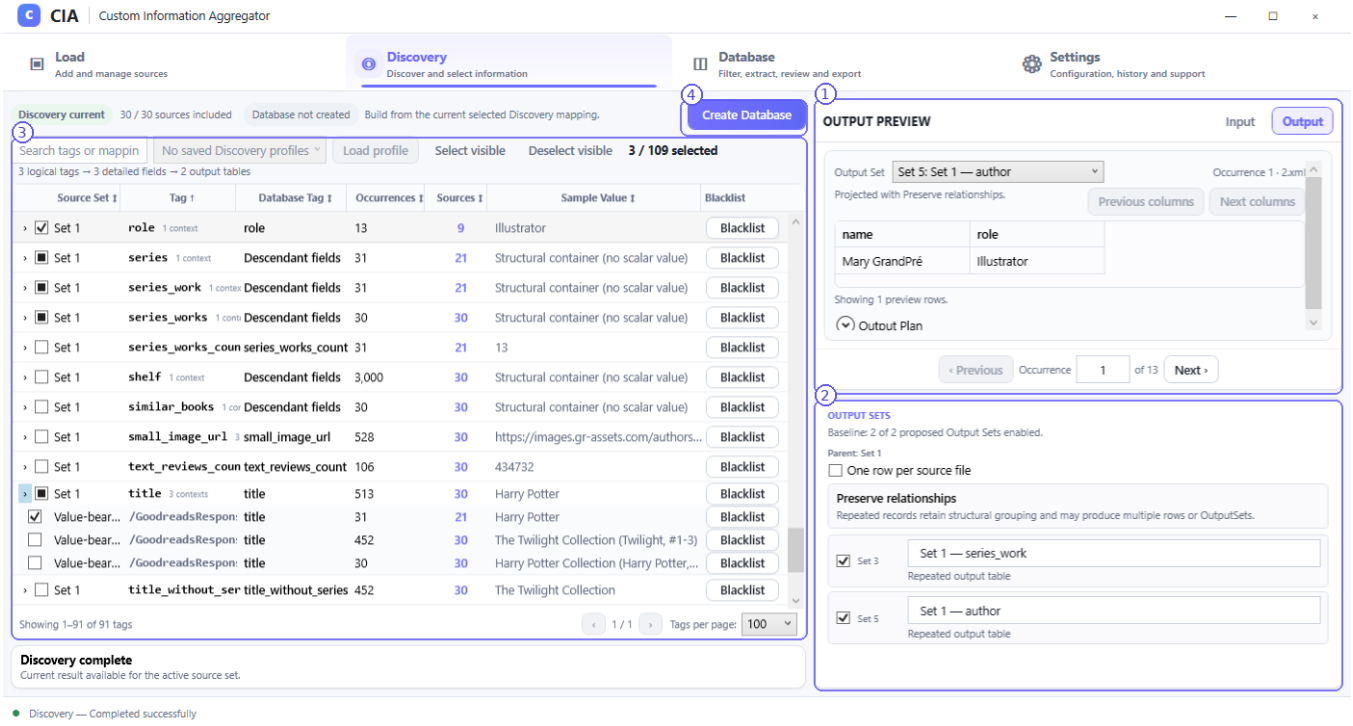


Figure 3: Discovery Output screen showing output sets and preview

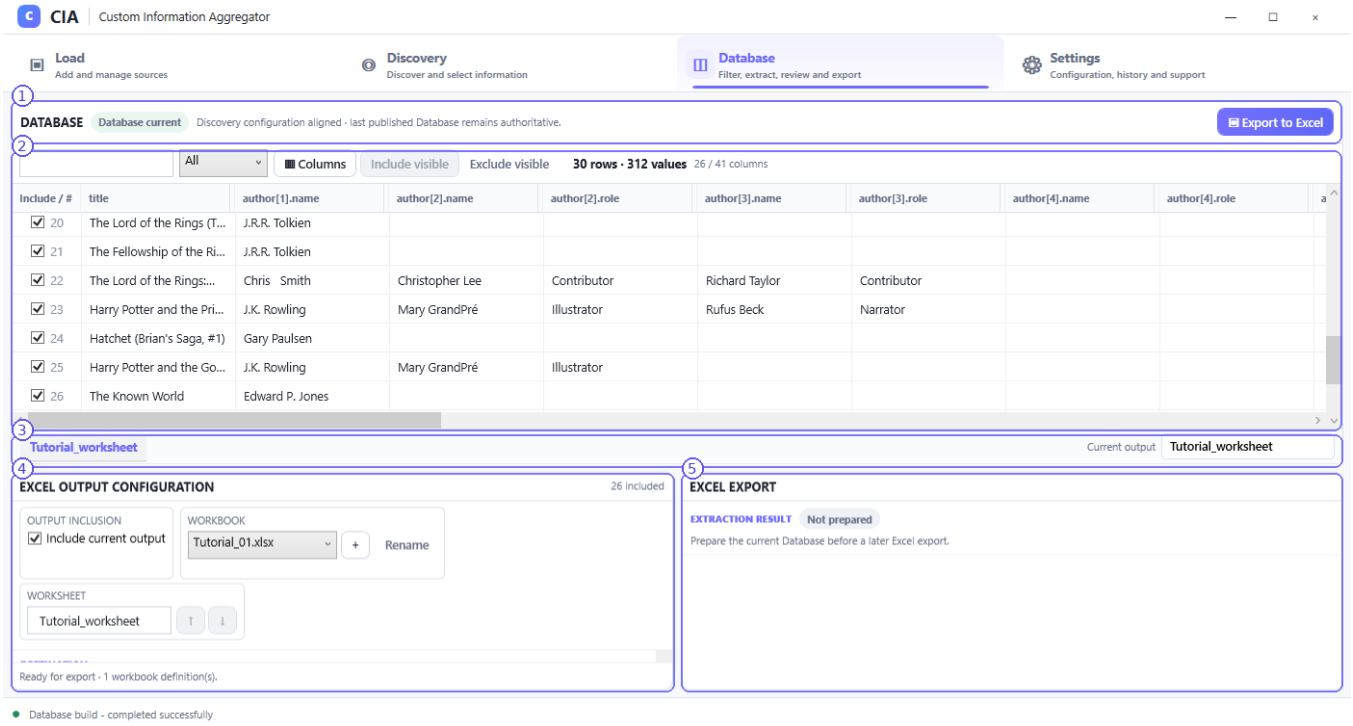


Figure 4: Database workspace showing included records and Excel output configuration

Expected result: An Excel workbook containing the included CIA OutputSet worksheet(s), according to your selections and naming. The precise number of rows, values and columns depends on the 30 XML files and the fields selected.

> **Where next?** Read Load and Discovery Input for the complete control-by-control explanation.

Walkthrough — workspaces and actions

The four top-level workspaces visible in the accepted screenshots are **Load**, **Discovery**, **Database**, and **Settings**. Discovery has **Input** and **Output** modes. The Database workspace also contains the Excel preparation/export controls.

Read in sequence:

1. Load — manage sources
2. Discovery Input — choose information
3. Discovery Output — approve the output plan
4. Database — review the results
5. Excel Export — save workbook(s)

The pages contain marked-up screenshots. Each numbered marker is explained immediately underneath the image.

Load — add and manage sources

The **Load** workspace controls which input files CIA knows about, whether each file is included, and which parent **Source Set** owns it. Adding a file does not itself generate the Discovery results or Database.

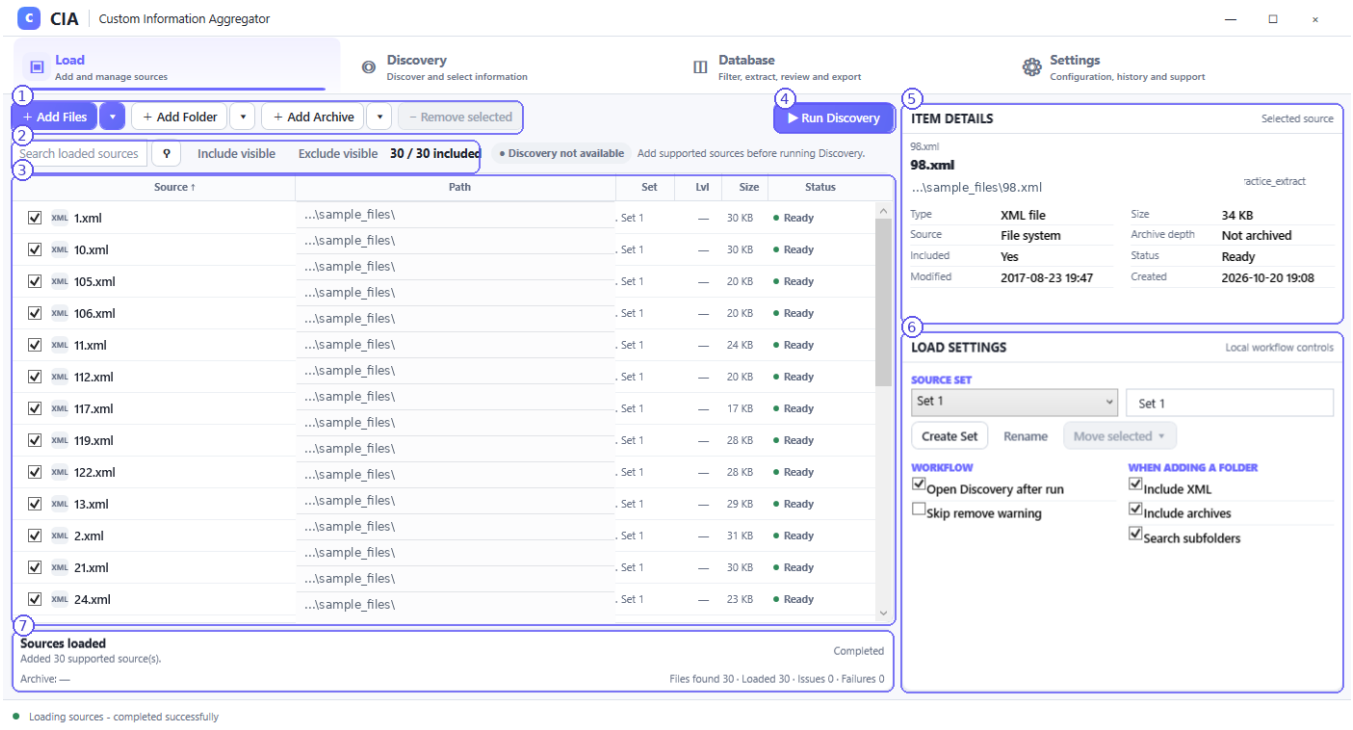


Figure 5: Load workspace with seven annotated regions

Screenshot callouts

1. **Add controls. Add Files**, **Add Folder** and **Add Archive** are the primary ways to supply sources. The adjacent dropdown arrows offer the control's available choices where applicable. Use the method matching your material; no manual archive extraction is required for supported archives.

2. **Search and inclusion.** **Search loaded sources** narrows the displayed list. **Include visible** and **Exclude visible** act on the visible subset. The inclusion counter in the example reads **30 / 30 included**.
3. **Source table.** Each row shows a source filename, path, set, archive level, size, inclusion checkbox and status. Click a row to inspect it. The inclusion checkbox controls whether that source participates; it is distinct from choosing rows for actions such as removal.
4. **Run Discovery.** Starts the Discovery pass for the current included sources. The screenshot shows the button available while Discovery results have not yet been created.
5. **Item Details.** Shows information about the selected source, including type, size, archive depth, whether it is included, and status. File paths shown in this manual are anonymized.
6. **Load Settings.** Select the active **Source Set**, create or rename sets, and move selected sources where enabled. The **Workflow** options include **Open Discovery after run** and **Skip remove warning**. Folder options cover **Include XML**, **Include archives** and **Search subfolders**.
7. **Operation summary.** Shows the latest load outcome, such as the number of sources found, loaded and failed. The bottom status strip also reports operations.

Adding material

1. Choose **Add Files**, **Add Folder** or **Add Archive**.
2. Select the source(s) in the Windows dialog.
3. Verify the loaded rows and the operation summary. In the screenshot, CIA shows **30 files found, 30 loaded, 0 issues, 0 failures**.
4. Check the inclusion column and use the visible-list controls if needed.
5. Run Discovery when the source list is ready.

About sets: CIA creates **Set 1** for the initial workflow. You can create additional parent sets when separate source groups require independent ownership. See Sets and OutputSets.

Removing a loaded entry

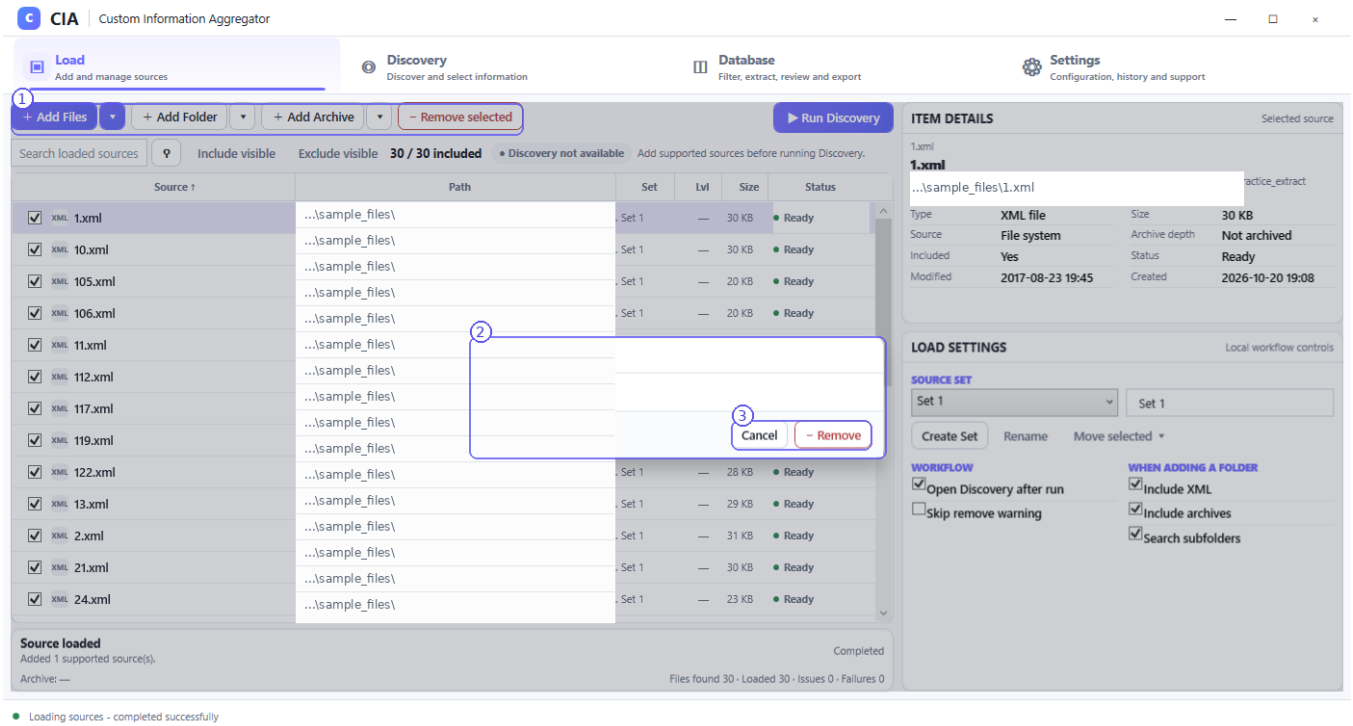


Figure 6: Remove-entry confirmation

1. Select the row or rows to remove. A selected action row is not the same thing as an included source checkbox.
2. Click **Remove selected**. CIA displays a confirmation showing the number of selected entries.
3. Choose **Remove** to confirm or **Cancel** to keep the entries. The **Skip remove warning** setting changes whether the confirmation is shown.

The screenshot documents removal **from the loaded source list**. It does not establish deletion of the XML file from your computer; do not interpret it as a file-system delete instruction.

Source status and readiness

- **Ready** indicates that a displayed source is ready for the supported workflow.
- The separate **Discovery not available** message means you have not yet established usable current Discovery results for that configuration.
- An operation may have its own success, warning or error message. Inspect the operation summary and **Settings → Log & Diagnostics** for details.
- If the source selection changes after processing, rebuild the affected downstream result before trusting the next export.

Discovery — Input mode

Input is the place to understand the actual XML information CIA found and choose what should be considered for output. It is a selection and inspection surface, **not** the final Database.

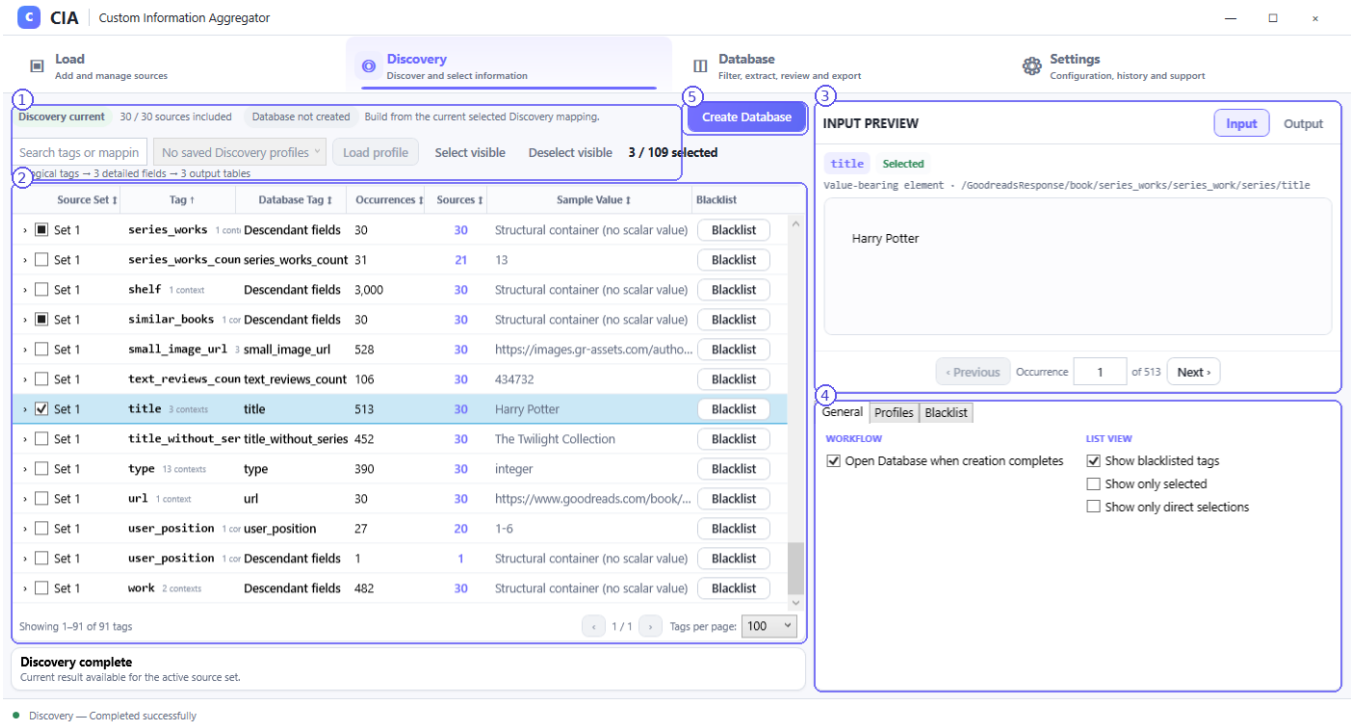


Figure 7: Discovery Input annotated screenshot

Screenshot callouts

1. **Selection toolbar.** Search tags or mapped names; use **Select visible** and **Deselect visible** on the displayed subset. The toolbar reports how many selections are active. Where a saved selection profile exists, choose it and select **Load profile**.
2. **Tag and structural-context table.** Rows show source set, tag, mapped Database tag, occurrence count, source count, sample value and blacklist action. Expand a logical tag to see separately selectable detailed contexts. A selected parent may show a mixed-state checkbox because only some descendants are selected.
3. **Input Preview.** Displays the selected occurrence and whether its detailed field is currently selected, plus the source structure and example value. Use the **Previous**, **Next** and occurrence-number controls to inspect examples.
4. **General / Profiles / Blacklist.** The lower-right tabs provide workflow/list settings and stored selection or blacklist profile management. They do not replace the main Input/Output mode switch.

5. **Create Database.** Materializes the currently approved interpretation once selection and Output Plan are ready. For a first run, inspect Output mode before using it.

Direct selection versus derived selection

A single named tag can occur at more than one structural location. For example, `title` may describe the book itself or a related series/work. **Selecting a tag name is not necessarily the same as selecting every structural meaning of that name.**

For precise output, expand the tag, inspect the detailed source contexts and select the field(s) that match the information you need. CIA can also derive related fields from structural selections, so the selected logical-tag count can differ from the detailed-field count. Use the summary and Output Plan to confirm the resulting projection.

Reading the counts

The screenshot displays different units:

- **Logical tags:** distinct discovered names or logical entries.
- **Detailed fields:** structurally distinguished selectable contexts.
- **Occurrences:** instances of a selected field/context found across sources.
- **Sources:** distinct source files containing that field/context.
- **Output tables / OutputSets:** proposed materialized result groups, not source-file or occurrence counts.

Do not expect those numbers to match. Likewise, previewing one occurrence does not mean the entire data set contains only one row.

Typical title/author selection

1. Search for `title` and inspect its available contexts.
2. Select the context for the book title rather than unrelated structural titles.
3. Find `name` and `role` under the appropriate author context; review their paths and sample values.
4. Inspect the Input Preview for the candidate fields.
5. Switch to Discovery Output to understand which rows and OutputSets the selection will produce.

The pictured fields and occurrence counts are **specific to the author's 30-file screenshot state**. They are illustrative, not required output values for another data set.

Discovery — Output mode

Output is the pre-Database decision surface. It shows how CIA proposes to interpret the selected fields **before** the full Database is built.

Screenshot callouts

1. **Output Preview.** Switch between **Input** and **Output** without losing the shared occurrence context. Choose a proposed OutputSet, inspect the projected columns/rows and open the **Output Plan** section. The preview is bounded: it helps you evaluate the projection without building the full Database.
2. **Output Sets.** Shows the parent set, enabled proposed derived OutputSets, editable names where supported and the interpretation mode. In the example, the normal mode **Preserve relationships** proposes multiple related output tables, and two are enabled.
3. **Selection table.** Input selections stay available on the left; changing the selection can change the proposed output plan. Review the effects before rebuilding.
4. **Create Database.** Builds the authoritative Database using the approved current selection and output mode.

Default: Preserve relationships

With **One row per source file** unchecked, CIA preserves relevant structural grouping. If the selected XML contains independent repeated families, CIA can propose multiple derived OutputSets for the

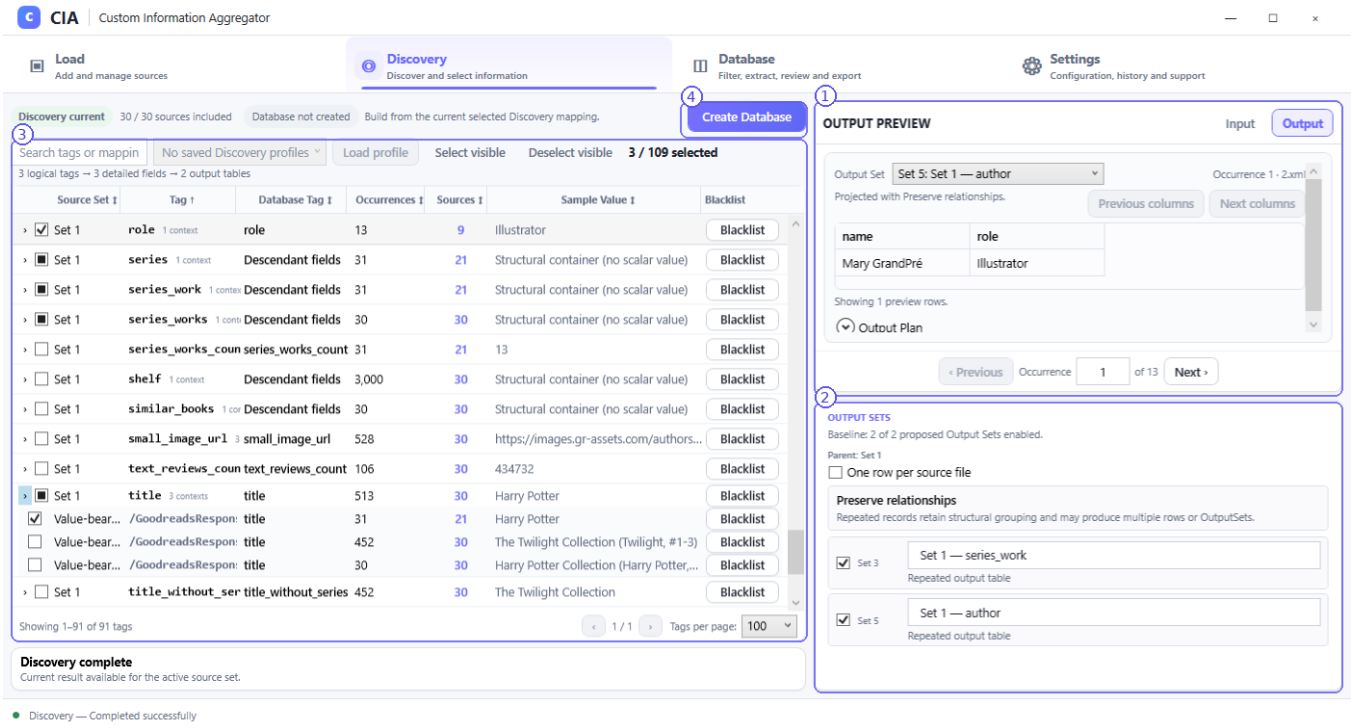


Figure 8: Discovery Output screenshot with annotated preview and output set region

parent set. A book title, author name and role may appear in different relationship contexts and should not be merged just because a tag label happens to match.

This is the recommended first choice. You can enable or disable the proposed OutputSets before Database creation. **One enabled OutputSet becomes one Excel worksheet.** Several worksheets may belong to the same managed workbook.

Optional: One row per source file

The checkbox **One row per source file** changes the output model for the current parent Source Set:

- **Unchecked (default):** Relationship-preserving OutputSets, potentially multiple tables for distinct record families.
- **Checked:** One combined OutputSet for that parent, with one output row per included, successfully interpreted source file. Repeated structural values may expand into numbered columns, with blank cells where a file lacks a field.

This option preserves source identity and structural association rather than forcing every file into compact columns. A source with no selected value can therefore still have an identifiable blank data row. In wide cases, the program warns when the planned width exceeds **500 output columns**; the warning is not automatically a refusal to continue. Excel's actual column limit remains a separate hard boundary.

The source-file mode preview can show **10 columns per page**. The source-local preview may be narrower than the eventual dataset-wide schema until the current full schema is known. A preview never removes legitimate values from the final output.

Known limitation: Real-world source-file mode can produce many sparsely populated repeated columns and blank source rows. It remains available by choice, with follow-up tracked for post-RC investigation (SPR-227). If the intended output is a concise relational table, prefer **Preserve relationships**. See Known Limitations.

Before creating the Database

1. Confirm the intended detailed-field selection in Input mode.
2. In Output, review the proposed groups and representative rows.
3. Select the interpretation mode for the parent set.
4. Confirm the required OutputSets are enabled and their names make sense.

5. Choose **Create Database**.

Important: Changing preview settings does not itself create a new published Database. The Database remains the authoritative materialized result; rebuild when you want changes to take effect downstream.

Database — review and prepare results

The **Database** workspace displays the actual generated OutputSet records. It is the authoritative place to inspect included rows and set the visible/selected columns before export.

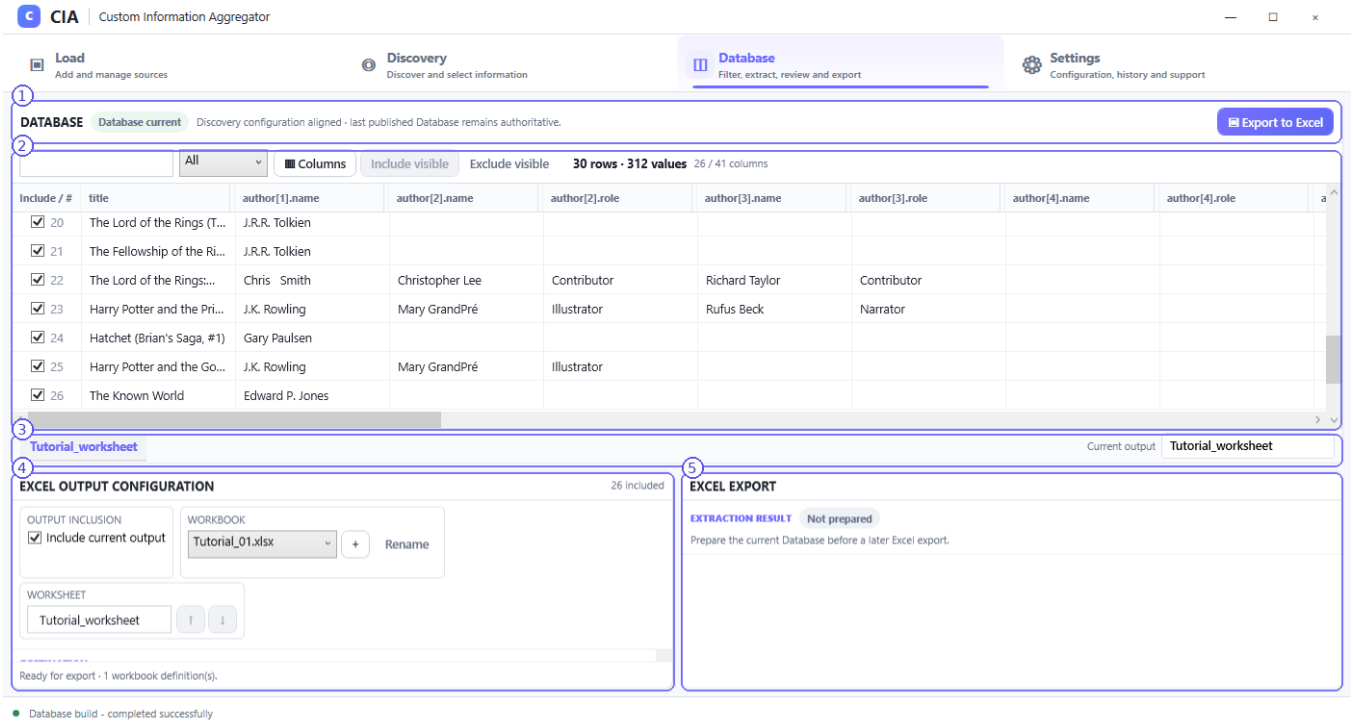


Figure 9: Database workspace annotated screenshot

Screenshot callouts

1. **Database status and export action.** The status label indicates whether the displayed Database is current for the Discovery configuration. **Export to Excel** begins the export workflow.
2. **Data grid and filtering.** Review field headers, values and included records. The search/filter area narrows the review; **Include visible** and **Exclude visible** apply to the visible rows where available. Horizontal scrolling provides access to additional columns.
3. **Output selector and name.** The lower strip identifies the currently displayed output. Output-Sets remain separate; the selected output has its own configured worksheet name.
4. **Excel Output Configuration.** Decide whether the current output is included, choose or create its workbook assignment, and edit the worksheet name/order controls shown.
5. **Excel Export panel.** Shows preparation/export status, such as **Not prepared**, before an export is run. Follow the on-screen state rather than assuming previous extraction results still apply to an edited Database.

Rows, values and columns are different quantities

The example screenshot shows **30 rows · 312 values · 26 / 41 columns**. These refer to different measurements:

- **Rows:** published result records in the current output (not Discovery occurrences).
- **Values:** stored nonempty/output value entries represented by the published output.
- **Included / total columns:** columns selected for presentation/export versus the full available set.

The exact numbers depend on the selected OutputSet, included rows and columns, interpretation mode and source files. Do not compare counters across different screenshot states as though they represent one unchanged configuration.

Column management

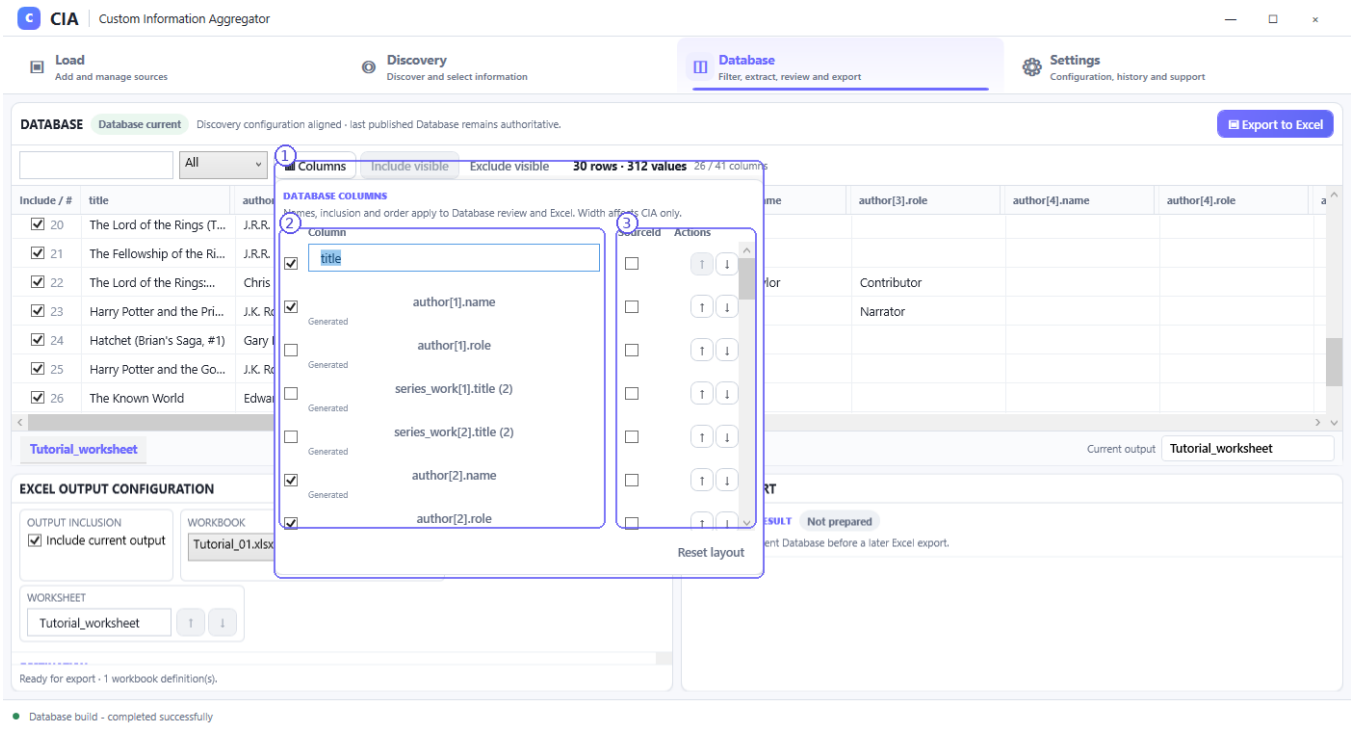


Figure 10: Columns flyout with annotations

1. **Columns panel.** Open **Columns** to manage how columns are presented and exported. **Reset layout** is available to restore the column layout settings shown.
2. **Include and rename.** Toggle included columns and change user-facing names where editable. Column names and order affect the current Database review and Excel value fields. A name override does not rewrite the original XML source.
3. **SourceId and ordering.** Where available, the **SourceId** checkbox includes a companion source-identity field; arrow controls change column order. Generated fields may display different editability from user-managed labels.

Database column widths primarily affect on-screen inspection. The included field list and presentation order are authoritative for the corresponding Excel value fields; workbook/worksheet routing is configured separately.

Preparing for the next step

1. Select the intended OutputSet.
2. Review inclusion and values in the data grid.
3. Open **Columns**; adjust included fields, names and order as required.
4. Configure its workbook/worksheet in the lower panel.
5. Use **Export to Excel** when ready. CIA handles the corresponding extraction/preparation within its export workflow; a separate manual destination-preparation step is not required.

For workbook behavior, see Excel Export and Columns and Excel Configuration.

Excel Export — worksheets, workbooks and save results

CIA writes selected structured data into `.xlsx` files. Export is initiated from the **Database** workspace. You do not need to open Excel to complete CIA's save workflow.

Export configuration

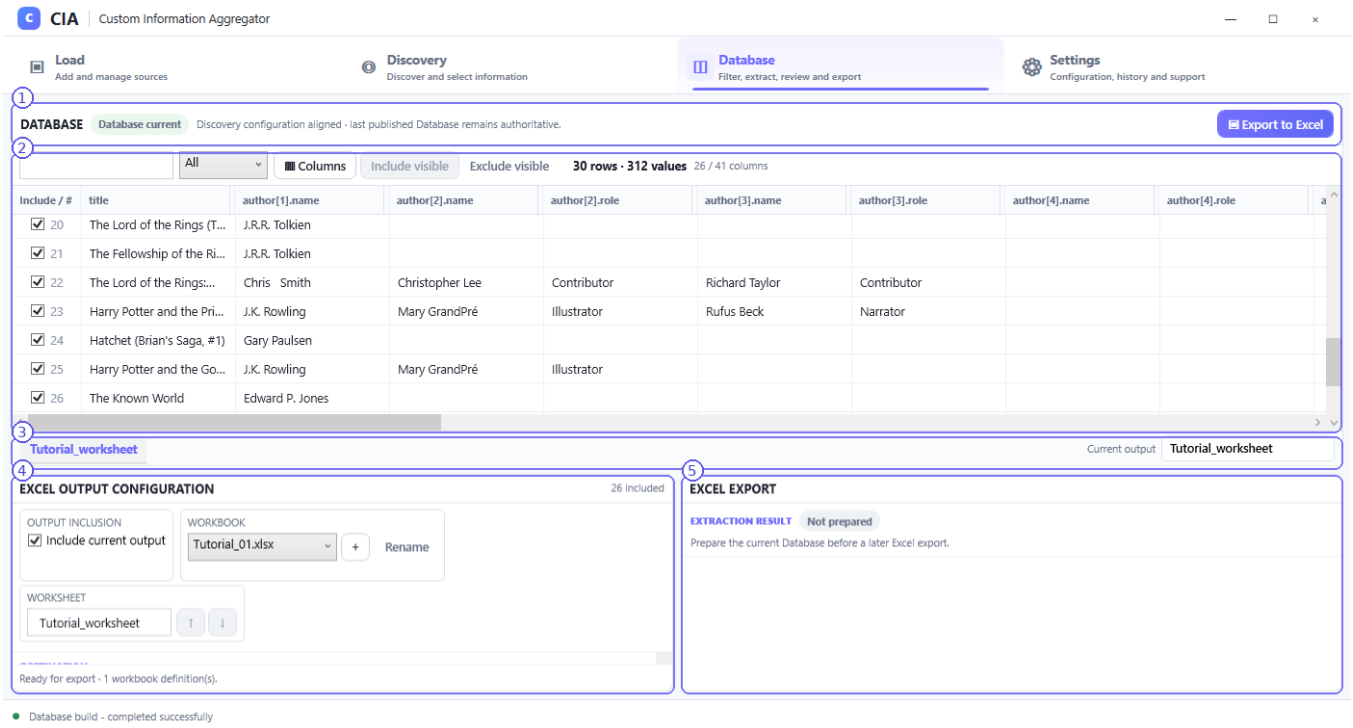


Figure 11: Database and workbook routing screen

1. **Include current output** only for those OutputSets you intend to export.
2. Under **Workbook**, select an existing CIA-managed workbook definition or create another using the visible controls.
3. Under **Worksheet**, set the visible worksheet name and order where supported.
4. Review the included Database columns through **Columns**. Their inclusion and order carry through to Excel value fields.
5. Select **Export to Excel**. Follow CIA's destination selection and save flow.

Routing rule: One derived OutputSet = one worksheet. Multiple OutputSet worksheets can share a workbook. CIA applies Excel-compatible naming and uniqueness rules; the initial name commonly combines its parent and derived set names, while the current UI lets you manage routing and names.

Saving a workbook

CIA supports the configured **Save to / Browse / Ask** destination behavior. Depending on the current setting, an export may proceed toward a configured folder or present the normal destination prompt. A direct **Export to Excel → Save** flow is valid; this manual does not require a prior separate preparation command.

If CIA is configured to open the exported file after successful export, it will attempt the post-export action as configured in Settings. This action is distinct from whether the workbook was successfully written.

Existing-file collision

1. **Existing Workbooks** lists destination workbooks already present, with an explicit action required for the affected output.
2. **Collision action** offers **Cancel**, **Overwrite** or **Different name** in the shown dialog. The selected action controls what happens to the existing workbook.
3. **Continue** confirms the chosen resolution for the batch. **Cancel batch** returns without proceeding with those workbook changes.

For a first tutorial export, choose a new workbook filename to avoid overwriting previous results. Never select **Overwrite** unless you intend to replace the named file.

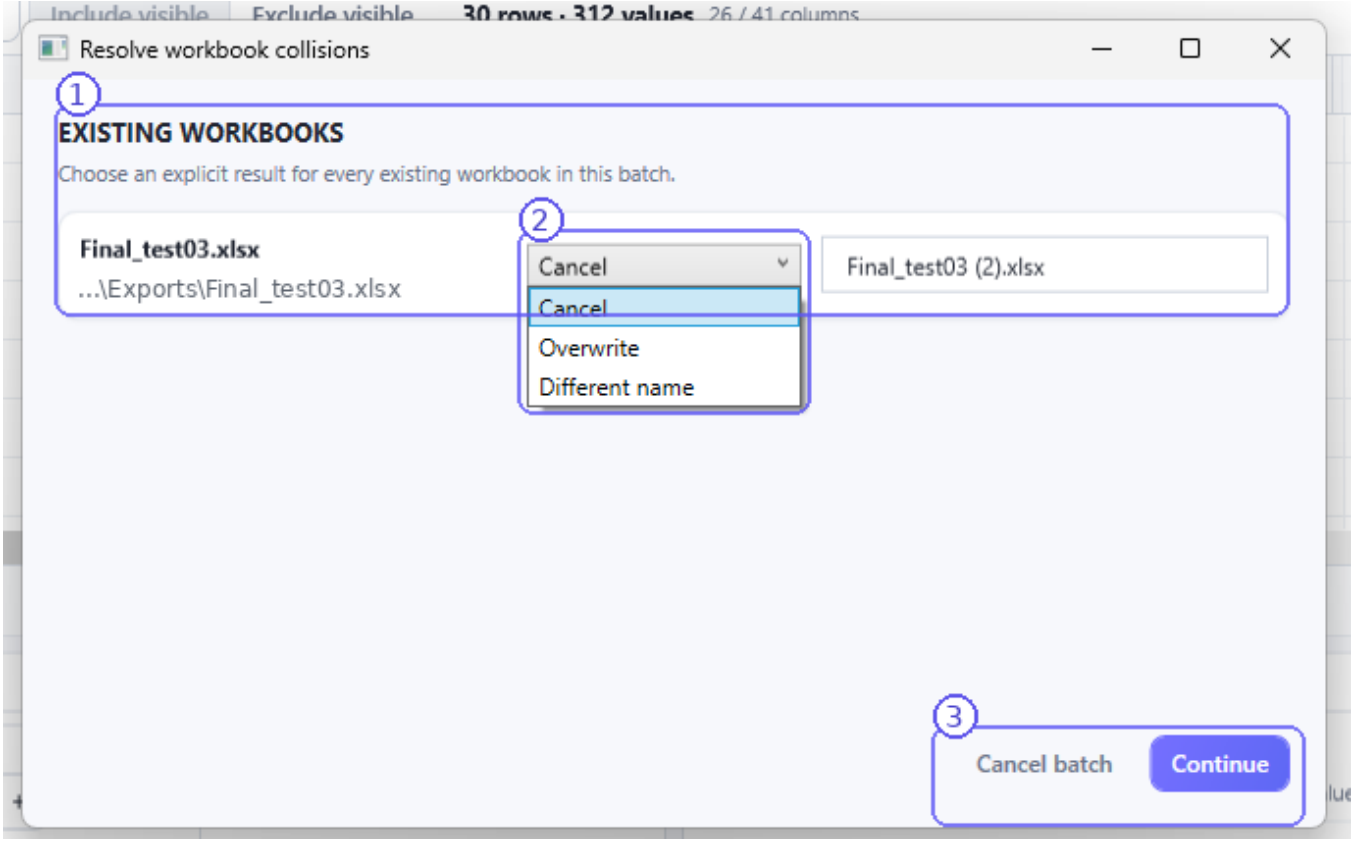


Figure 12: Existing workbook collision dialog annotated

Batch export

When multiple OutputSets are enabled, CIA can route worksheets to one or more workbooks. Check each workbook definition and per-output inclusion before starting. A collision affecting one or more destinations may require a deliberate resolution; do not assume the entire batch silently overwrites files.

What CIA confirms

The application reports completion or failure through the visible operation status and **Settings → Log & Diagnostics**. A successful export means CIA completed the workbook-save workflow; the user's downstream Excel analysis is outside the scope of this interface manual.

If your selection or Database mapping changes later, update/rebuild the relevant result and then export again so the workbook reflects the intended current state.

Feature Reference

Use these pages when you already know the workflow and want to understand a particular setting or concept.

- Source Sets and OutputSets
- Profiles and Blacklists
- Columns and Excel Configuration
- Settings and Diagnostics

For step-by-step navigation, use the Walkthrough.

Source Sets and OutputSets

CIA uses two different concepts that can otherwise be easy to confuse.

Term	What it means	Where you work with it
Source Set (parent Set)	A user-managed group of input sources. It determines which files belong together for Discovery.	Load / Load Settings
OutputSet (derived Set)	A proposed and then materialized table produced from a parent Source Set and the selected structural interpretation.	Discovery Output, Database, Excel

Example from the manual

All 30 selected Goodbooks XML files belong to **Set 1** in the Load screenshot. The Discovery Output screenshot shows that CIA may propose **more than one OutputSet** for this single parent, such as a `series_work` table and an `author` table. Those are not additional input folders or separate copies of the XML files.

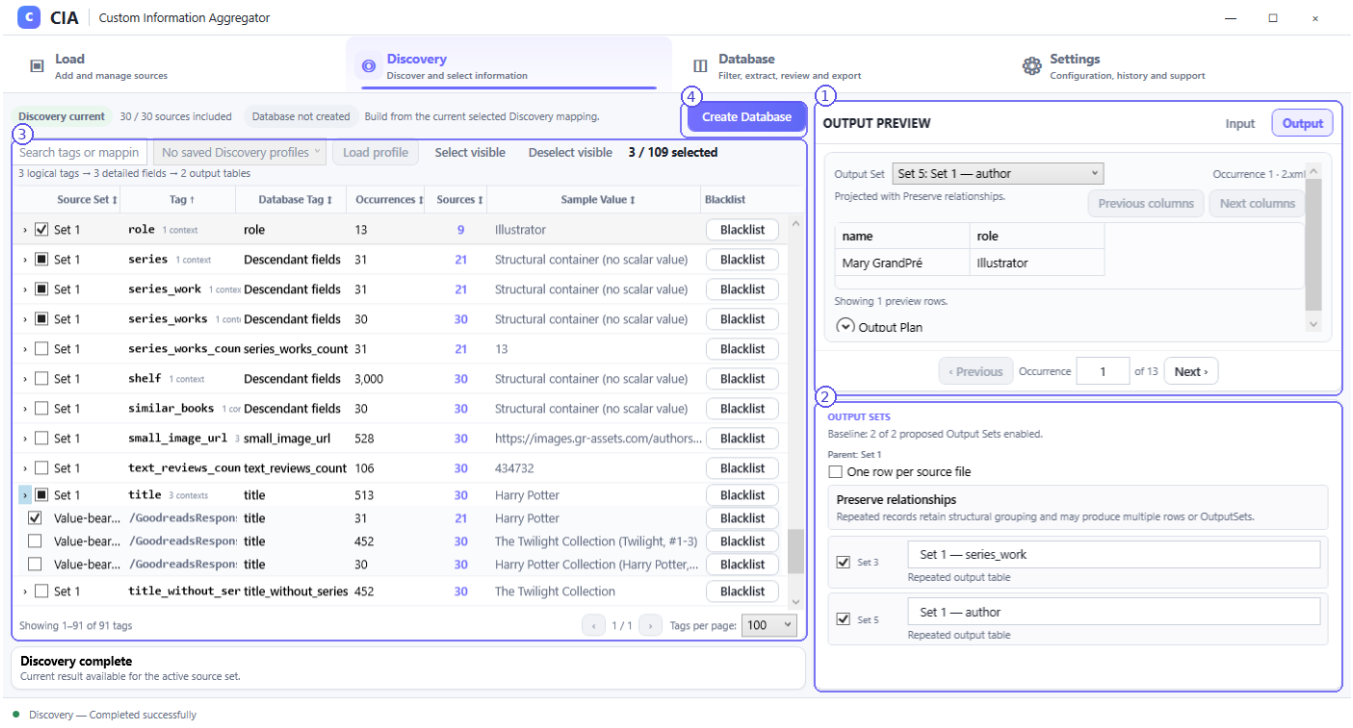


Figure 13: Discovery Output shows proposed derived tables

How to choose the interpretation

- **Preserve relationships:** Build structurally meaningful derived tables from the selected fields. One parent Source Set may produce multiple OutputSets.
- **One row per source file:** Combine the parent's selected information into one source-associated table, potentially with numbered repeated-value columns. It is optional and off by default.

These modes describe different output projections. They do not merge unrelated parent Source Sets with one another. Toggling a mode changes the **proposed next build**, not the already published Database instantaneously.

How output reaches Excel

Parent Source Set → enabled OutputSet(s) → Database output(s) → one worksheet per OutputSet.

If two different OutputSets each contain a field called `name`, the shared label alone does not create an automatic join between them. The user can correlate them later using whatever keys and provenance the outputs make available.

Provenance and SourceId

CIA maintains source identity and lineage so that outputs can be traced back to their originating file/source context. The optional **SourceId** companion column is exposed in the Database Columns panel. Identical visible names do not by themselves establish identical structural meaning.

Selection Profiles and Blacklists

Two reusable mechanisms appear in the Discovery sidebar. They serve different purposes:

- **Selection profile:** Saves a set of Discovery information selections for reuse.
- **Blacklist profile:** Records fields/tags you want excluded from the Discovery selection experience.

Selection profiles

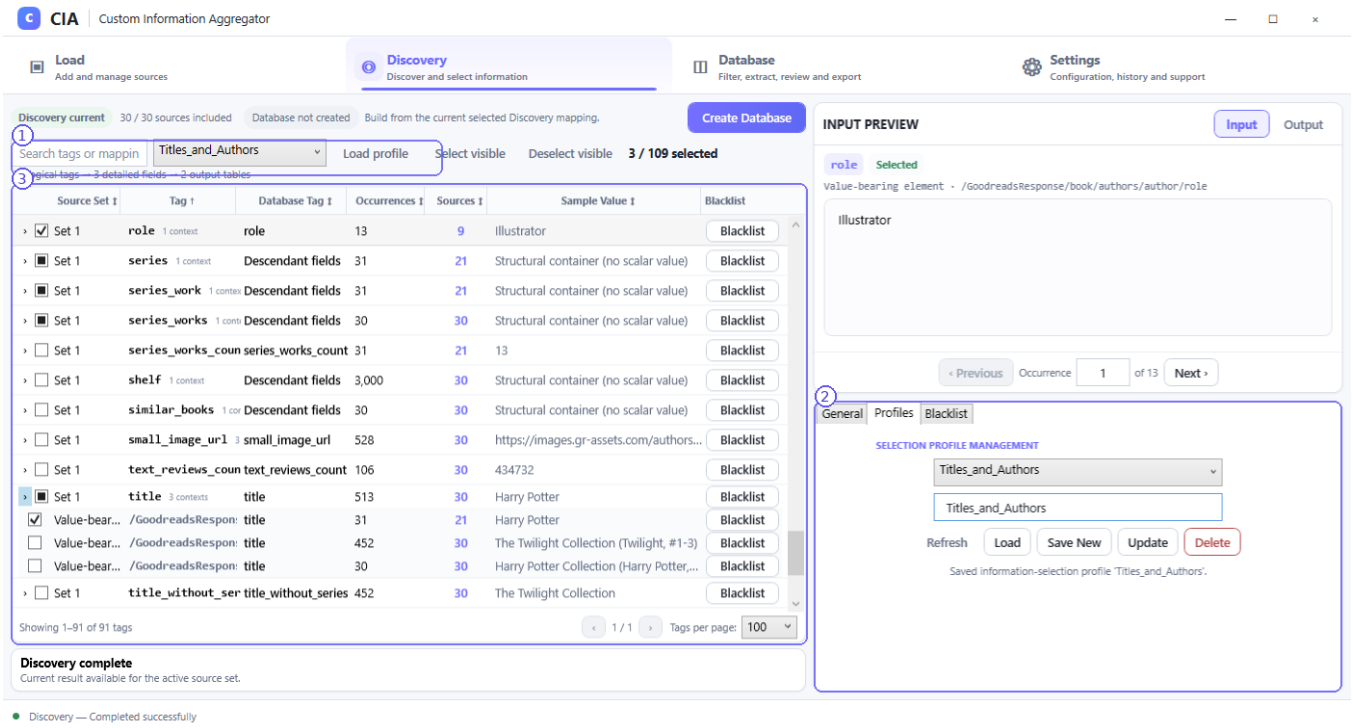


Figure 14: Discovery Profiles screen annotated

1. **Discovery toolbar profile selector:** Choose a saved Discovery profile and use **Load profile** to apply it when available.
2. **Profiles panel:** Name, save, load, update or delete saved information-selection profiles through the displayed controls. The screenshot illustrates a profile named `Titles_and_Authors`.
3. **Selected detailed fields:** Inspect the tag list and checkmarks to understand what the currently applied selection contains; do not infer selections exclusively from the profile name.

A saved profile is a convenience for repeated configuration. Review its actual selections against your current sources and contexts before building the Database.

Blacklist profiles

1. **Blacklist entries:** Blacklisted rows are visually distinguished; use the row's blacklist action to control whether it is blocked. An entry can be restored to neutral selection state through the supported UI.

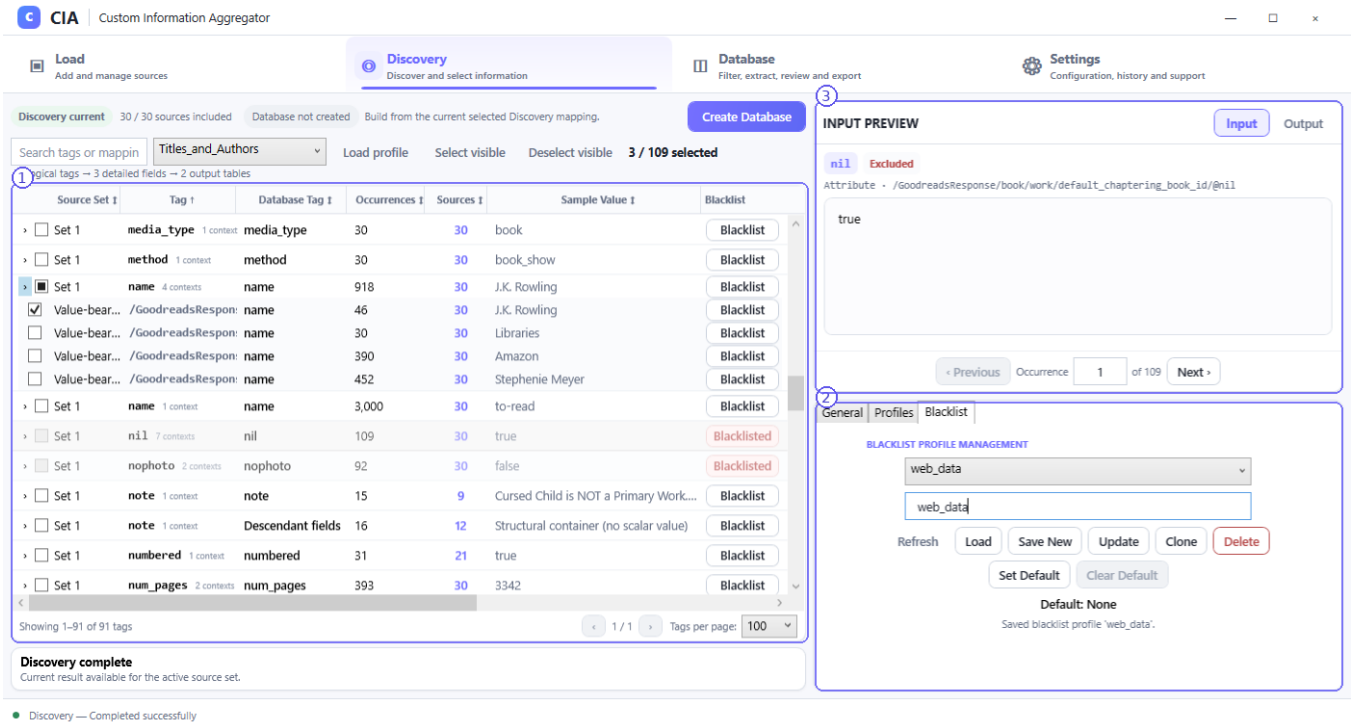


Figure 15: Discovery Blacklist profile screen annotated

2. **Blacklist panel:** Use the displayed **Load**, **Save New**, **Update**, **Clone**, **Delete**, **Set Default**, and **Clear Default** controls as applicable. The screenshot shows a saved profile called `web_data` and displays its default-state text.
3. **Input Preview:** Inspect a selected row's occurrence and its blacklist state when you need to understand what that entry represents.

Visibility is not selection

The Input **General** tab includes switches such as **Show blacklisted tags**, **Show only selected**, and **Show only direct selections**. These are list-view controls. Hiding a row from the list does not by itself mean that row has been deleted from the source file.

Good practice

After loading a selection or blacklist profile, inspect the current tag tree and Discovery Output plan. Profiles can simplify repetitive work, but the current sources and structural contexts remain the authoritative basis for the proposed output.

Columns, metadata and workbook configuration

This page collects the Database and Excel controls that shape what a saved workbook looks like.

Database Columns panel

1. **Open and reset.** The **Columns** control opens the column list; **Reset layout** restores the supported layout defaults.
2. **Name and inclusion.** The name field controls the presented column label where editing is allowed. The leading checkbox determines whether that field is included. Generated columns may have restrictions.
3. **SourceId and order.** Select the companion source-id field where relevant; use up/down arrows to organize field order.

The Database's included columns and presentation order are the expected basis for the Excel **value-field** selection and order. This is separate from workbook naming, metadata fields and post-export settings.

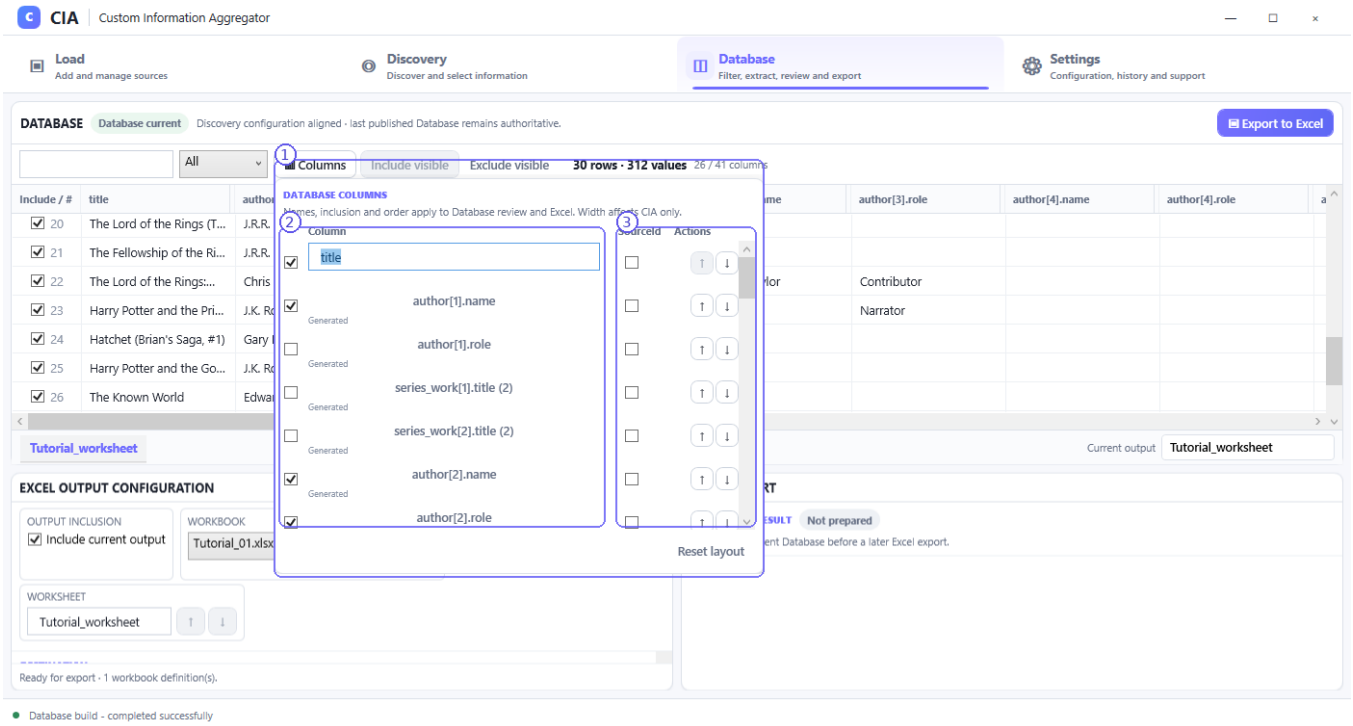


Figure 16: Annotated Columns dialog

Excel Output Configuration

From the lower-left **Excel Output Configuration** region, you can:

- include or exclude the current output from the next export;
- assign the output to a CIA-managed workbook definition;
- add or rename a workbook definition using the controls provided;
- name and order its worksheet when the controls are enabled.

CIA prevents incompatible worksheet names by applying Excel naming and uniqueness rules. Worksheet boundaries follow OutputSets, not arbitrary shared field names.

Repeated data and wide outputs

A relationship-preserving output may put different repeated record families into different worksheets. The optional source-file mode instead preserves one source row while repeated structures expand into numbered column groups. This can result in large, sparse workbooks.

CIA warns when the planned output crosses **500 columns** in source-file mode, counting relevant generated and metadata fields. The warning gives you an opportunity to reconsider selection; it does not authorize silently dropping fields. Check Known Limitations before using source-file mode as a compact reporting format.

When to rebuild

If you change source inclusion, detailed-field selection, OutputSet enablement or output interpretation, inspect the current/updated status and build a new Database before exporting those changes. Editing the name or order of included Database columns affects presentation and subsequent export configuration but does not edit the underlying XML.

Settings and Log & Diagnostics

Settings contains general application configuration, managed storage controls, operation logs and help links.

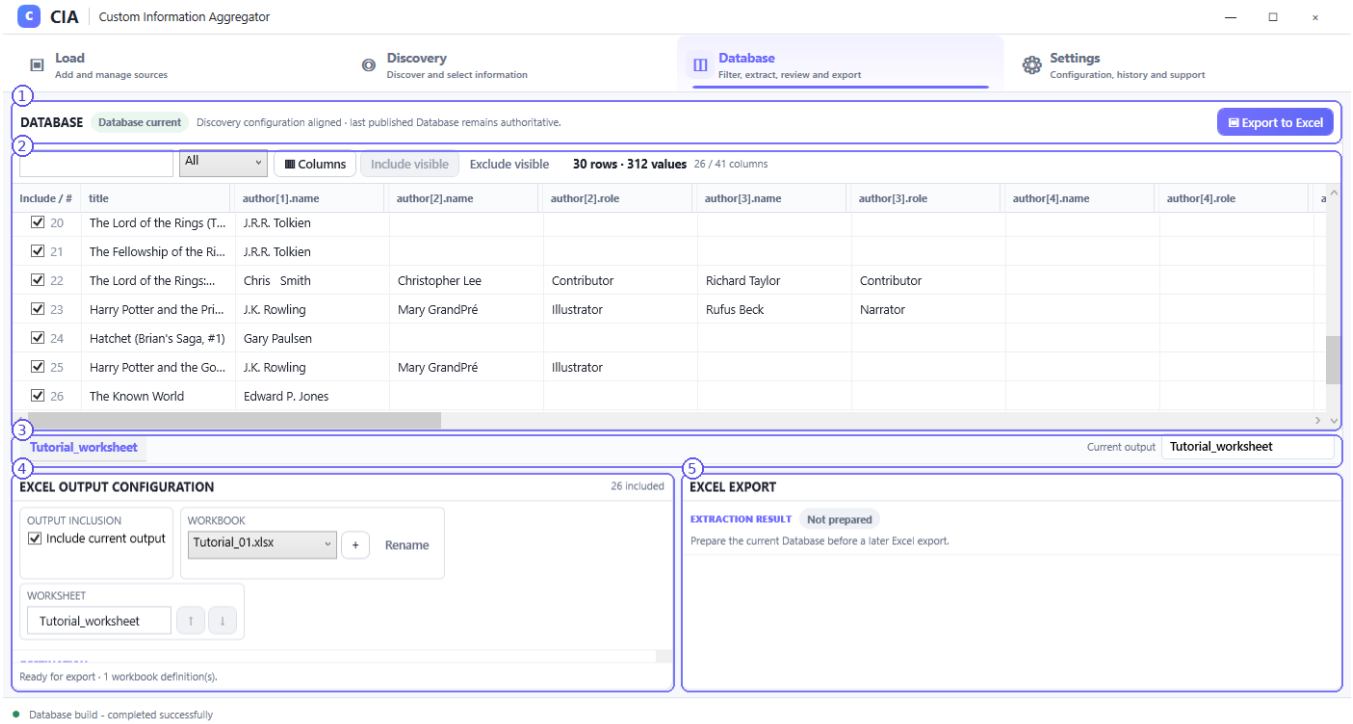


Figure 17: Workbook and worksheet controls

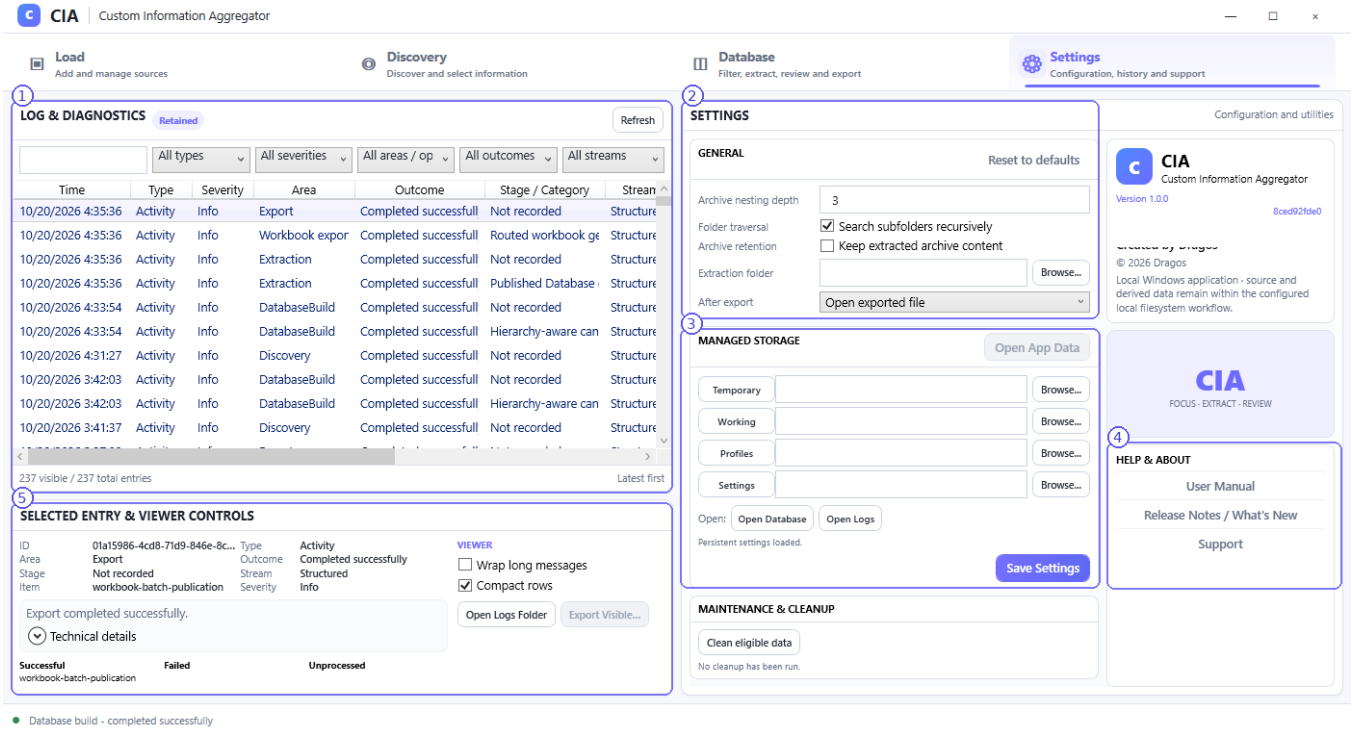


Figure 18: Settings workspace with five annotated regions

Screenshot callouts

1. **Log & Diagnostics.** Review the chronological activity list. Filter by type, severity, area/operation, outcome and stream. Select an entry for more detail; the screenshot shows completed Database and export activities.
2. **General settings.** Set the supported archive nesting depth, folder traversal behavior, whether extracted archive contents are retained, and the extraction folder. **After export** controls behavior such as opening the exported file. Click **Save Settings** to persist changes.
3. **Managed Storage.** Shows paths/actions for temporary, working, profile and settings areas. The visible controls also include **Open Database** and **Open Logs** where available. Storage settings should be changed deliberately.
4. **Help & About. User Manual**, **Release Notes / What's New** and **Support** open their configured documentation destinations in a browser. The top area displays the application version/build information.
5. **Selected Entry & Viewer Controls.** Inspect an activity's detail and technical information; use **Wrap long messages**, **Compact rows** or the available log-folder actions to read diagnostics more comfortably. The lower-left panel is an inspection surface, not an Excel data grid.

General settings

Setting	Purpose
Archive nesting depth	Sets the configured limit for traversing supported nested archives.
Search subfolders recursively	Controls folder traversal under selected folders.
Keep extracted archive content	Controls retention of eligible extracted archive material.
Extraction folder	Chooses where extraction-related output is stored.
After export	Configures supported behavior after a successful export, such as opening the exported file.
Reset to defaults	Restores supported setting defaults; review the effect before applying it.

Log workflow

1. Use **Refresh** if you need the latest activity list.
2. Narrow the list with filters or the search box.
3. Click a record and read its details below, including operation and outcome.
4. For additional information, expand **Technical details** or use **Open Logs Folder** where available.

Logs help distinguish an unexpected result from an incomplete operation. The log's **Area**, **Outcome** and **Stage/Category** labels should be read together.

Maintenance and unavailable capabilities

Clean eligible data is a maintenance action for supported temporary/session data; inspect its prompts before proceeding. **Working State / Recovery** and **Decomposer** are **not available as active v1 user workflows**. Their historical design references do not mean these tools can be used in this release.

Troubleshooting

Start by checking the relevant workspace status and **Settings → Log & Diagnostics**. If a task was cancelled, failed or used a previous configuration, the screen may still display an older published Database.

Symptom	What to check / do
Discovery not available after loading	Confirm intended sources are included and **Ready**, then click **Run Discovery**.
Some files are missing from the current output	Inspect **Load** inclusion, source status, active parent Set and any file/parse failures; then re-run Discovery/build as appropriate.
Desired tag appears but produces an unexpected result	Expand its **structural contexts** and check direct selection, derived selection and Input Preview. A tag name can occur at several paths.
Output Plan has more tables than expected	In Discovery Output, inspect enabled derived OutputSets and the default **Preserve relationships** mode. Independent repeated families may need separate tables.
Database is **out of date** or the new selection is not reflected	Inspect the status and select **Create Database** using the current Discovery configuration. Preview changes do not automatically replace a published Database.
A row looks empty in source-file mode	The mode can preserve a source row whose selected fields are absent. Check the source identity and selected fields before treating it as lost data.
Unexpectedly many columns	Inspect nested/repeated fields and whether **One row per source file** is enabled. Use **Preserve relationships** for a more compact family-oriented projection.
Large-column warning	Review your selection and structural repetitions. Above 500 output columns is a warning in source-file mode, not permission to drop data.
A Database value appears clipped	Scroll horizontally, adjust relevant column width where supported, or inspect the value without assuming that the underlying export is empty.
Workbook already exists	Use the explicit collision dialog: **Cancel**, **Overwrite**, or **Different name**. Check the filename carefully.
Export ends without the expected workbook	Inspect destination behavior (**Save to / Browse / Ask**), the result status and **Log & Diagnostics**. Confirm the output was included and the intended workbook name was selected.
Application link opens an unfinished documentation page	This is an RC documentation-draft limitation until the agreed manual and associated release pages are integrated.

If an operation is cancelled

Use CIA's supported cancellation controls and inspect the resulting status. Do not assume partial output was published. Where the application preserves a previous valid Database after a failed or cancelled rebuild, it remains the previous published state, not the pending one.

Reporting a reproducible issue

Record the CIA version, workspace and operation, the user-visible message, source format, output mode and any relevant diagnostic result. Avoid sharing proprietary XML or identifying local paths when preparing a public issue.

For help resources, use Settings and Diagnostics or Support.

Known limitations and scope

This section describes the **accepted Release Candidate scope** and clearly separates working functionality from deferred work.

Optional source-file output: sparse columns and blank rows

One row per source file is available and supported as an opt-in output interpretation. Because repeated structures are represented with numbered columns and source identity is preserved, a data set may produce many columns that are empty for most files. Sources with none of the selected values may still produce identifiable blank rows.

A real-world TEM validation exposed blank source rows and excessive sparse column expansion; the owner accepted the default **Preserve relationships** / Root output as the useful v1 alternative. Further investigation is scheduled **after RC as SPR-227**. These observations do not establish missing stored values or license the manual to recommend discarding columns indiscriminately.

Suggested user choice: For a concise, family-oriented output, leave **One row per source file** unchecked. Enable the source-file mode when you specifically need source-aligned rows and can accommodate repeated numbered columns.

Output preview is not the full Database

Output Preview is intentionally bounded. Depending on current schema knowledge and projection mode, it may show a sampled/local view or a paged view (10 data columns per page for source-file mode). **Database** is the authoritative full materialization stage.

Deferred / unavailable functionality

- **Working State / Recovery** is quarantined from the accepted v1 interface and is not an available workflow.
- **Decomposer** is not available in the accepted user interface.
- Historical repeated-data layout options such as **Align repeated groups by position**, **Structural rows**, **All combinations**, and **Number repeated values into columns** are **not presented as current v1 user choices**.
- CIA does **not** claim to automatically join independently derived OutputSets merely because field names are the same.

Boundaries of this tutorial

The examples are drawn from an author's local 30-file Goodbooks selection. Their screenshots demonstrate the UI, not a certified result for every possible collection of Goodbooks XML files. The documentation does not distribute the 30 sample files or claim that the final installer has been released.

For installation or compatibility statements, consult the separate Installation Guide, rather than treating these workflow screenshots as an installation test.

Glossary

Term	Meaning in CIA
Source	An individual input file or supported file within a package/archive.
Included source	A loaded source enabled to participate in processing.
Source Set / parent Set	A user-managed group of input sources.
Discovery	Inspection of available input structures and selection of useful information.
Input mode	The Discovery view for source fields, contexts and source-value preview.
Output mode	The Discovery view for projected rows, output interpretation and proposed OutputSets.
Logical tag	A displayed discovered tag name before considering all distinct contexts.
Detailed field / structural context	A field distinguished by its actual source structure/path.

Term	Meaning in CIA
Occurrence	One encountered instance of a field in the source material.
OutputSet / derived Set	A proposed or materialized result table formed from selected input structures.
Output Plan	The pre-Database representation of proposed output grouping.
Preserve relationships	Default mode for relationship-preserving output tables.
One row per source file	Optional mode for a single row per included successfully interpreted XML source, with repeated values potentially spreading across numbered columns.
Database	The materialized review surface that controls included rows and columns for downstream export.
SourceId	A companion source identity that helps trace results to their source.
Workbook	An `.xlsx` file that can contain one or more worksheets.
Worksheet	One sheet; CIA uses one worksheet per enabled derived OutputSet.
Blacklist	A controlled exclusion state used in Discovery.
Selection profile	Saved configuration for information-selection choices.
Current / out of date	Status indicating whether a published processing result aligns with the active configuration.